

STEP 3

ANALYZING YOUR PERSONAL NETWORK

This is the heart of the assignment and the portion to which you should devote the greatest time.

Drawing on the course readings, lectures and your own in-depth knowledge of your personal network write a 4-6 page analysis of your personal network. In your analysis, you will seek to answer two questions:

1. What does your overall network look like, and why does it look this way?
2. How do the two networks described in Tables 1 and 2 compare? How are they similar and how are they different and why? (*Hint: If you haven't already guessed, Table 1 draws more on your strong ties, while Table 2, draws more on your weaker ties. You'll probably want to call these your "strong tie network" and "weak tie network" in your paper.*)

You may organize the paper however you choose and you may use or omit sub-headings according to your own evaluation of which option will make your argument stronger. However, you should have an introduction and conclusion, and I strongly recommend that unless you have a strong reason for doing otherwise, you begin with your overall network and then proceed to the comparison.

When you write your analysis, you will need to use the numbers you have calculated, but the focus should be on painting a picture of your network and explaining it, rather than just listing numbers measures. For example, it is better to say "My weak-tie network is twenty percentage points more homophilous by age and five percent less homophilous by ethnicity than my strong tie network...<explanation of why>..." Rather than "Forty-five percent of my weak tie network is within 5 years of my age. Twenty-five percent of my strong tie network is within 5 years of my age."

You may multiply the proportions you have calculated by 100 to get percentages where percentages will be easier to write about.

Your analysis will be evaluated according to the following criteria:

1. Your ability to use course concepts to describe your social network.
2. Your ability to draw on your knowledge of social network analysis to explain why your personal network looks the way it does.
3. The clarity, organization, and persuasiveness of the writing.

A Note On Balancing Course Materials with Your Own Knowledge of Your Network

Your focus in this paper is on applying concepts and knowledge from the course to your own personal network. Of course, everyone's network is different, which means not everyone – not even most people – have the mean number of discussion partners or the average level of ethnic homophily. But if your network doesn't look quite like the average networks that we read about that doesn't mean that you can't or shouldn't use the things you've learned to explain your network.

Wherever there is an explanation of *why* networks look the way they do, there is also an implicit hypothesis of *when* they don't look that way. So regardless of whether your personal network is typical, you should be able to draw on course materials to explain why your network looks the way it does. For example, we know from Marsden (1987) that kin-centred networks tend to be more homophilous by ethnicity. His explanation of *why* this is the case is that most people are the same

ethnicity as their family members. Implicit in that explanation is the understanding that if you have a kin-centred network and *are not* the same ethnicity as many of your family members – perhaps you were adopted, or have married into a family of a different ethnicity – we would expect a kin-centred network to be *less* homophilous by ethnicity.

You can and should bring in this kind of knowledge of factors that have shaped your social network. Linking this kind of knowledge to the course materials shows a strong understanding of network analysis. However, remember that the focus should remain using your knowledge of social network analysis to understand your network, not on personal reflection or storytelling about your life or your relationships. For example, you might write:

I live in an ethnic neighbourhood and volunteer at an ethnically-oriented community centre. Therefore, many of the people I meet and have the opportunities to form friendship with share my ethnicity. This high level of induced homophily explains why my weak ties network is as ethnically homophilous as my strong tie network, even though it is less kin-centred.

But you shouldn't write:

In 2005 my family moved from Oakville to Little Malta. This was the first time I went to school with other students from Malta and so I rejoiced in the opportunity to make friends with people who shared my love of *fenkata*. Through one of my new Maltese friends I learned of the Little Malta Community Centre where I started volunteering to set up tables for community fundraising dinners. Soon it seemed like everyone I met even casually was Maltese. Sixty-three percent of my weak tie networks shares my ethnicity and 70% of my strong tie network shares my ethnicity.

Try to think about using your in-depth knowledge of your network to talk about *how the rules worked in your case*, even if this is different from how they usually work. The focus is on networks and how they form, not on your life story.

FAQ:

1. May we use “I” in the paper?

Yes. For example, you might say “I live in an ethnically homogenous neighbourhood.” However, you probably shouldn't say things like “I think,” “I believe,” “I feel” etc. because these phrases are almost always redundant and irrelevant. They act as filler. Filler is bad.

2. What about citations and references?

The only sources you will draw on for this assignment are course readings. Therefore, if you are referring to a course reading, include a parenthetical citation (e.g. “(Marsden 1987)”) but you do not need to include a list of references, since these will all be on the syllabus.

3. Should we/can we *quote* from the course readings?

I won't say no, but I can't think of any reason or context where you would *need* to. And if you don't *need* to, it's just filler. Filler is bad, and you should omit it.

4. What if I'm having trouble?

There is no need to struggle alone. Come to my office hours. Talk to me or the TA. If you're having trouble with the writing portion of the assignment – or even if you're not – I strongly encourage you to make an appointment with your college writing centre.

5. What else should we know?

If you haven't already, you should take a few minutes to read the University of Toronto's Code of Conduct on Academic Matters.